

EVERYDAY MILLIONAIRES

Take Mike and Stephanie, for example. These millionaires from South Carolina are now retired and enjoying the life of their dreams—and they have only themselves to thank for it. Mike came from a middle-class family with two working, well-educated parents. His father was a scientist in the space program, and his mother was a preschool teacher. Because his parents grew up during the Great Depression, they were intentional about teaching Mike the value of hard work, the dangers of debt, and the importance of saving. Mike and his siblings never got an allowance; they had to work for their spending money as children. He even started his own window-washing and shoe-shining businesses at age sixteen. That taught him early on that his finances were up to him and that no one was going to hand him anything he didn't earn for himself.

After completing a PhD in theater, Mike spent his time directing plays and teaching theater classes at a local college. He eventually became a dean of the college of arts and humanities at the school, and later accepted a position as the dean of arts at a school in South Carolina. During this time, he met and married Stephanie, who worked her way through medical school. Throughout their marriage, Mike and Stephanie lived like his parents taught him. They never had a dime of credit card debt, and they maintained a comfortable yet modest lifestyle. Mike said, "It just wasn't important to me to have the best cars or stay at the best hotels." What was important to him? Saving. Mike and Stephanie made saving a priority throughout their marriage—especially when their incomes increased at the top of their careers. When everyone else was spending, they were building wealth. They took advantage of company-sponsored retirement plans and company matches, along with other investments over a long period of time. Even now, in retirement and with a net worth of \$2.6 million, they are making smart decisions by holding off on Social Security distributions until age seventy, when they can get the maximum benefit.

Mike and Stephanie attribute their success to their lifelong saving habits, avoiding debt, and working with an investment professional; their commitment to improving themselves; and their earning potential through education. They both knew early on what they wanted their lives to be, and they did whatever it took to make their millionaire dreams a reality. If you want to join them in millionaire status, you need to get a handle on one of the most prevalent character traits we discovered about millionaires: an extreme sense of personal responsibility.

A CRISIS OF RESPONSIBILITY

Most people aren't doing well with their money. Our research team did a study on the state of retirement in America and found that 56% of Americans are losing sleep over their retirement. They aren't sure how